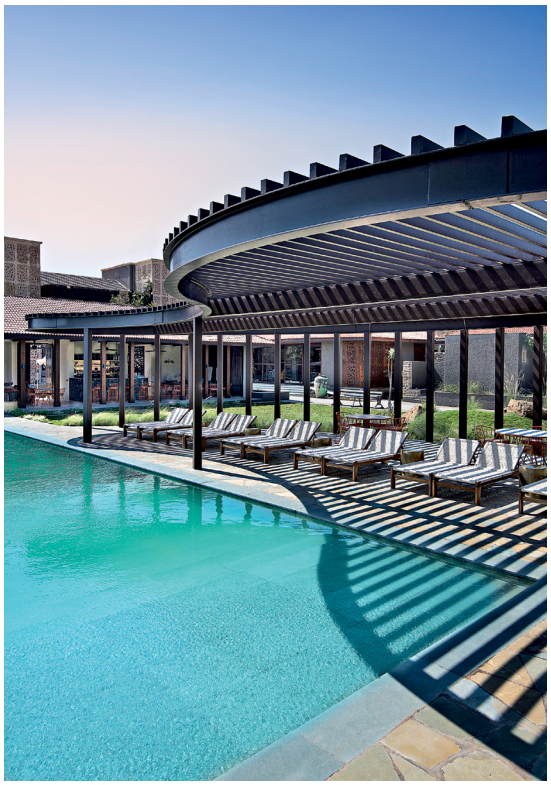
(From right) Afternoon tea at the Pool House, the ultimate space in Aramness Gir to unwind and enjoy the serenity; the culinary delights revolve around local produce from the Edible Garden







Taking us along to our tryst with the lions is Adil Arif, a naturalist with the newly-opened Aramness resort outside Sasan Gir. As our jeep zips along the road into the park, we breathe in the fragrance of tiny white wild *karaunda* flowers, a galaxy of stars sprawling on either side of the track. Arif explains that lions like to rest under the dense thickets of this shrub, the only green shade when the jungle turns a leafless brown in summer. As we peer excitedly at each passing *karaunda* bush, he grins. "There are easier ways to spot a lion these days," he says. "Just look for the jeeps that have stopped. Or ask a tracker." Indeed, it is a pair of mustachioed men in uniform who point us towards a little clearing off the road. There, in plain sight, sits a lioness! Five cubs loll around her, watching with mild curiosity as we ooh and aah and click pictures from a safe distance.

The high cuteness quotient of the lion cubs—all furry-eared and baby-pawed—is a bit offset by the ripe stench of rotting meat that wafts our way. Close by lies the carcass of a cow, its flesh now being slowly digested inside said lioness and cubs. Although Gir has its share of wild ungulates—we saw herds of velvet-antlered chital as well as solitary nilgai and sambhar—it's the cattle kept by the Maldhari communities that are the main prey of lions. Like the Maasai in East Africa, the Maldhari have herded livestock in the company of lions for centuries. Their symbiosis is one that the Aramness staff are keen to have their guests appreciate.